Senior JCO assisting me expressed his helplessness, all the cash was accounted for. It was one of the few times I was carrying my wallet and wonder of wonders, it had some 100-plus rupees in it which I gave to that boy, I don't remember who, but the situation was resolved. Sub Jasmel Singh, who was part of the group, piped up, '*Sahib-ji, meinu yaad hai. Oo main siga*' (Sir, I remember. That was me). I guess that's the day I really became one of them. Little acts of kindness go a long way. The ranks we wear on our shoulders are only a reflection of the long hours, sweat and blood that our boys have put in.

Quite rightly is it said, 'There are no good Officers or bad Officers; only good Regiments or bad Regiments.' Our men are our constituency, the only difference being that they don't elect us. All the more reason therefore, to do what is right by them. It is when they are mired in quicksand, an operation gone wrong, for example, that we have to extend a helping hand. I was fortunate that my superiors always held my hand and backed me up, and I only hope that I have repaid their trust and faith in me, by doing the same for my subordinates.

In the second week of April, the Army Commanders Conference was held. On 16 April, I hosted a dinner for all the Army Commanders and PSOs at the Army House. It was during the course of the evening that the announcement for Gen Manoj Pande to be the next COAS was received. It was a strange coincidence that my nomination had also been made while at dinner at the Navy Chief's residence. Veena and I were the first to congratulate Manoj and Archana, and we opened a bottle of bubbly to mark the occasion. It was like déjà vu.

Veena and I called on President Ram Nath Kovind and his wife, to pay our respects and bid them farewell. The President and his wife were their gracious selves. In fact, the President used to always call me up on Army Day or my birthday to

Copyright © Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation